

better cities for you than the one you're attached to—or if there aren't, that information will help cement your original choice.

Then, zoom in on the smaller details. One thing you might be tempted to ignore is your personal commute time. Though houses might be better on the other side of town, do you really want to spend hours each day commuting to and from work? When considering a home that would add to your current commute, we strongly urge you to drive your expected route during rush hour to see just how bad it will be. If sitting in traffic and spending more money on gas is your idea of a good time, go for it! (If you work from home, the world is your oyster.)

While it may sound irrelevant if you don't have children, buying a house in a good school district is always a plus. Homes in a good district sell faster and for more money than houses in a mediocre or worse district. Kids or no kids, you'll still enjoy the benefits of that district when you go to sell. However, you should also note that a good school district often comes with higher property taxes. Make sure those higher expenses are worth it by looking at similar homes in both districts—at least online—to compare pricing.

Last but not least, some parts of the country have huge floodplains while others have smaller ones or none at all. If your property is located in a floodplain, you'll need to purchase flood insurance, which can be quite expensive. Flood insurance is available only through the federal government, which unfortunately means no price shopping.

How updated should the home be?

Are you looking for something more polished, or something with which you can force appreciation? If the latter, you should know which projects you're willing to take on. Home renovation shows might be a great source of entertainment (*move—that—bus!*), but the projects on TV are never as simple as they seem. You might walk into an older home and think, *Well, I can just tear down that wall to open up the kitchen. Instant value-add!* Though the idea is tempting, you might regret that decision down the road.

Make sure you consider your DIY skills before diving into showings. What projects might you be willing to tackle to add value to a home? What's completely off the table? This depends entirely on your own